

KATHLEEN (KATE) CANDON

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research goal is to enable robots to be better at learning from the everyday users with whom they interact and collaborate. I explore how robots can use additional information already available in an interaction (e.g., facial expressions, human actions) and how robots can prompt users for more information (e.g., reminders to provide feedback) to more quickly understand human preferences.

Keywords: Human-Robot Interaction (HRI), Robotics, Artificial Intelligence (AI)

EDUCATION

Yale University

Expected 2026

Ph.D in Computer Science

Advisor: Marynel Vázquez

Member of: Interactive Machines Group (Marynel Vázquez)
Social Robotics Laboratory (Brian Scassellati)

Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)

2016

B.S. in Mathematics with Computer Science

Phi Beta Kappa Honor Society

AWARDS

AAAI Doctoral Consortium Participant & Student Scholarship

2025

Selected to participate in the AAAI/SIGAI Doctoral Consortium, a yearly workshop that provides an opportunity for a group of Ph.D. students to discuss and explore their research interests and career objectives with a panel of established researchers

HRI Pioneers

2024

Selected to participate in the Human-Robot Interaction Pioneers Workshop, a yearly workshop held at the ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction that brings together a cohort of the world's top student researchers

AAMAS Doctoral Consortium Participant & Student Scholarship

2023

Selected to participate in the Doctoral Consortium at the International Conference on Autonomous Agents and Multiagent Systems, a yearly workshop that provides the opportunity to interact closely with established researchers and other students in the field

Honorable Mention for National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship

2020, 2022

CRA-WP Grad Cohort for Women

2022

Travel grant to attend event designed to provide critical mentoring, networking, and professional development opportunities to increase the representation of populations underrepresented in computing and education in graduate studies in computing

JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS

- J1 Sydney Thompson*, **Kate Candon***, and Marynel Vázquez (To Appear). The Social Context of Human-Robot Interactions. In *Annual Review of Control, Robotics, and Autonomous Systems*. Accepted for publication July 2025.

* denotes equal contribution

CONFERENCE PUBLICATIONS

- C9 Nicholas C., Georgiou, Shuangge Wang, Joel Banks, **Kate Candon**, Drazen Brscic, and Brian Scassellati (2025). When Teaching A Robot, People Employ Different Feedback Strategies: Some Are More Effective Than Others. In *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society (CogSci)*, vol. 47, July 2025.
- C8 **Kate Candon**, Nicholas C. Georgiou, Rebecca Ramnauth, Jessie Cheung, E. Chandra Fincke, and Brian Scassellati (2025). Artificial Intelligence for Future Presidents: Teaching AI Literacy to Everyone. For *Symposium on Educational Advances in Artificial Intelligence (EAAI)* in *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence*, February 2025.
- C7 **Kate Candon**, Nicholas C. Georgiou, Helen Zhou, Sidney Richardson, Qiping Zhang, Brian Scassellati, and Marynel Vázquez. REACT: Two Datasets for Analyzing Both Human Reactions and Evaluative Feedback to Robots Over Time. In *Proceedings of the 2024 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)*, March 2024.
- C6 **Kate Candon**, Jesse Chen, Yoony Kim, Zoe Hsu, Nathan Tsoi, and Marynel Vázquez. Nonverbal Human Signals Can Help Autonomous Agents Infer Human Preferences for Their Behavior. In *Proceedings of the 22nd International Conference on Autonomous Agents and Multi-Agent Systems (AAMAS)*, May 2023. [23% Accept. Rate]
- C5 **Kate Candon**, Helen Zhou, Sarah Gillet, and Marynel Vázquez. Verbally Soliciting Human Feedback in Continuous Human-Robot Collaboration: Effects of the Framing and Timing of Reminders. In *Proceedings of the 2023 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)*, March 2023.[25% Accept. Rate]
- C4 Jake Brawer, Debasmita Ghose, **Kate Candon**, Meiying Qin, Alessandro Roncone, Marynel Vázquez, and Brian Scassellati. Interactive Policy Shaping for Human-Robot Collaboration with Transparent Matrix Overlays. In *Proceedings of the 2023 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)*, March 2023. [25% Accept. Rate]
Best Technical Paper Award
- C3 Qiping Zhang, Austin Narcomey, **Kate Candon**, and Marynel Vázquez. Self-Annotation Methods for Aligning Implicit and Explicit Human Feedback in Human-Robot Interaction. In *Proceedings of the 2023 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)*, March 2023. [25% Accept. Rate]
- C2 **Kate Candon**, Zoe Hsu, Yoony Kim, Jesse Chen, Nathan Tsoi, and Marynel Vázquez. Perceptions of the Helpfulness of Unexpected Agent Assistance. In *Proceedings of the 10th International Conference on Human-Agent Interaction (HAI)*, December 2022. [39% Accept. Rate]
- C1 Nathan Tsoi, **Kate Candon**, Deyuan Li, Yofti Milkessa, and Marynel Vázquez. Bridging the Gap: Unifying the Training and Evaluation of Neural Network Binary Classifiers. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS)*, November 2022. [26% Accept. Rate]

PEER-REVIEWED LATE BREAKING REPORTS

- R1 Houston Claire, **Kate Candon**, Olivia Clark, and Marynel Vázquez. Multiplayer Space Invaders: A Platform for Studying Evolving Fairness Perceptions in Human-Robot Interaction. In *Companion of the 2024 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI Companion)*, March 2024.

WORKSHOP PAPERS

- W4 **Kate Candon**. Towards Better Robot Learners: Leveraging Implicit and Explicit Human Feedback Together in Human Robot Interactions. In *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence (AAAI)*, vol. 39, no. 28, February 2025.
[AAAI Doctoral Consortium](#)
- W3 **Kate Candon**. Leveraging Implicit Human Feedback to Better Learn from Explicit Human Feedback in Human-Robot Interactions. In *Companion of the 2024 ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI '24)*, March 2024.
[HRI Pioneers](#)
- W2 **Kate Candon**. Towards Creating Better Interactive Agents: Leveraging Both Implicit and Explicit Human Feedback. In *Proceedings of the 2023 International Conference on Autonomous Agents and Multiagent Systems (AAMAS)*, May 2023.
[AAMAS Doctoral Consortium](#)
- W1 **Kate Candon** and Marynel Vázquez. Context2: On the importance of the context of context in human robot interaction. In *HRI workshop on Context-Awareness in Human-Robot Interaction*, March 2022.

MENTORING

Undergraduate Thesis

Helen Zhou (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2025
Hanah Leventhal (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2023
Crystal Wang (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2023
Sam Danquah (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2023
Coco Sack (<i>Social Robotics Laboratory</i>)	2022

Undergraduate Researcher

Alyssa Quarles (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2025
Lena Qian (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2024
Sydney Richardson (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2023
Helen Zhou (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2022-2023
Ariel Melendez (<i>Social Robotics Laboratory</i>)	2022
Jesse Chen (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2021-2022
Yoony Kim (<i>Interactive Machines Group</i>)	2021
Zoe Hsu (<i>Interactive Machines Group, STARS program</i>)	2021

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Artificial Intelligence for Future Presidents, Yale University <i>Teaching Fellow, Discussion Section Instructor</i> A one-of-a-kind experimental course designed to teach non-majors about artificial intelligence	Spring 2024, Spring 2025
Artificial Intelligence, Yale University <i>Teaching Fellow</i>	Spring 2022

SERVICE

HRI Pioneers — <i>Publicity Chair</i>	2025
HRI Late Breaking Reports — <i>Program Committee Member</i>	2025
Yale Computer Science Graduate Student Advisors Committee — <i>Representative</i>	2022-2023

Reviewing

ACM/IEEE Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)
Conference on Computer Supported Collaborative Work and Social Computing (CSCW)
International Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)
AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence (AAAI)
ACM Symposium on User Interface Software and Technology (UIST)
Cognitive Science Conference (CogSci)
Transactions on Human-Robot Interaction (THRI)

SELECTED OUTREACH

EVOLUTIONS, Peabody Museum @ Yale University <i>Workshop Facilitator</i>	Spring 2025
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EVOLUTIONS offers a rich, informal learning environment for 100 of the most passionate, high-potential teens in New Haven. We conducted a workshop in which we brought students to the Interactive Machines Group to demonstrate our research and then conducted a design activity to brainstorm activities for our robots at the museum.

Girls Advancing in STEM (GAINS), Yale University <i>Tech Talk & Lab Tour Lead for Interactive Machines Group</i>	Fall 2022
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The GAINS conference brought together 121 high school female and non-binary students along with 30 teachers from public, private, and charter schools across the United States who have an interest in STEM with volunteer scientists from Yale University and Sikorsky Aircraft to explore STEM topics and careers.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Massachusetts Executive Office of Health and Human Services (EOHHS) <i>Senior Strategy Manager, MassHealth</i>	2018-2020
McKinsey & Company <i>Business Analyst</i>	2016-2018